to Cabinet in June 1923, a series of communications had passed between the two governments, the result of which was ‘that the Russian Soviet Government had given way on every point...’[63] Curzon believed himself ‘to have won a considerable victory’.[64] The Bolsheviks had even moved to replace their representative in Kabul, Fedor Raskolnikov, who had proved so objectionable to Britain. They did refuse to recall B.Z. Shumiatskii, from Tehran, as Curzon had also demanded, but this was not in fact a crucial issue.[65] Indeed, in February 1923 Loraine had noted how Shumiatskii’s ‘tactless blundering has done more to revive [the] fear and detestation of the Russians than could have been accomplished by any other agency. With him as a political opponent, it’s like taking candy from a baby.’[66]

As for Anglo-Soviet relations themselves, Thomas Preston, the British representative in Petrograd, believed that Curzon’s note ‘has resulted in our reaching a new phase in Anglo-Russian relations’. In Preston’s opinion, ‘The prestige of Great Britain in Russia has been...restored, and would seem to have reached its highest point since the evacuation of British troops from Russia in 1919.’[67] How far this was actually the case, and how far Preston simply supposed it to be true, is difficult to tell. One thing for sure is that Curzon’s feelings towards the Bolshevik regime had not improved, nor were they likely to. The foreign secretary had made this perfectly clear in April 1922 when Loraine had asked whether he should participate in the Bolshevik celebrations of 1 May. It was decided by the Foreign Office staff that the ambassador ‘should do the minimum consistent with courtesy’. Curzon reluctantly agreed: ‘very well. But I abominate these flirtations with a declared enemy.’[68] For the foreign secretary the Bolsheviks would always be the ‘enemy’, no matter how many diplomatic agreements Britain signed with them. Yet, despite his best efforts, a Soviet presence in southern Asia was by now an established reality. All Curzon could now do in response was to adjust his expectations for Britain accordingly, and keep a sharp eye on those Bolsheviks.

Russians, Turks, Afghans and Indians